



MONTHLY UPDATE

Botswana: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-31 • 45 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • INCLUSION • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The data-protection commission issued a [determination and enforcement notice against the public service management directorate on 17 July 2026](#), taking the government payroll portal offline. It is the first published enforcement against a government body, and the portal has no reopening date.

The public accounts committee was told on 30 July that the [national public key infrastructure is funded, begun, incomplete and non-operational](#): P423m secured, control transferred to the intelligence directorate, no working system, no timeline and no accountable owner.

A parliamentary answer of 28 July attributed identity-card delays to [too few production staff and ageing equipment with frequent breakdowns](#), running since the start of 2026 with no backlog figure and no restoration date.

Two instruments were made rather than reported on: a [national e-waste management strategy launched with an inter-agency memorandum on 13 July](#), carrying no targets or budget, and the [first phase of a regional fibre corridor carrying traffic from 6 July](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

On 13 July the regulator and the environment department [launched a national e-waste management strategy and signed an inter-agency memorandum](#). No targets, budget, collection volumes or implementation dates were published, and the strategy document itself is not on file.

Legislation and regulation

Two instruments took effect and both widen the state's reach over digital services. The [electronic payment services amendment regulations are in operation](#), extending scope to money or value transfer services, taking fit-and-proper tests through to beneficial owners and 10% shareholders, and making unlicensed operation punishable by P1,000,000 and five years. Float interest is ring-fenced and directed by the central bank, with promotion of financial inclusion dropped from the permitted uses and not replaced by any customer entitlement. Separately the [remote-service VAT Act took effect on 1 June](#), charging 14% on non-resident digital and remote services against a stated collection target of about P450m a year.

Data protection

The data-protection commission [issued a determination and enforcement notice against the public service management directorate on 17 July, with compliance evidence due within one month](#). The directorate published a privacy notice on 6 July and completed an impact assessment on 13 July; the determination itself is not held, and both accounts of it are press carries.

It is the commission's second enforcement action on record, after non-bank financial institutions in February 2026, and its first against a government body. A year earlier the commission ran on [three contract officers with no premises, no published address, no website and no deputy commissioner](#); it still has no budget organisation or line of its own.

Regional collaboration

The [ICT memorandum with Namibia was signed at Kasane on 7 August](#) between the two ICT ministries, with their operators and regulators present, covering digital transformation, cybersecurity, connectivity and skills development. It had been [announced for signature the day before](#) as an extension of existing roaming and submarine-cable transit cooperation. The signed instrument itself is not held, and no term, funding or data-governance provision is published; what the two sides did publish alongside it is operational, and is recorded under connectivity below.

Finance

New investments

The Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa [signed a EUR110m mixed credit facility with the Botswana Development Corporation, and a EUR500,000 grant to the agriculture university, at its board meeting in Gaborone on 15 July](#). The facility is to the development corporation rather than to a ministry, which places the lending at one remove from the budget the transformation plan is executed through.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The [Plumtree-Bulawayo section of a regional fibre corridor went live on 6 July, carrying traffic at 800Gbps equipped on equipment rated over 10Tbps](#), with a second phase to Livingstone due September 2026. The corridor is stated as a Botswana-Zimbabwe-Zambia route; the live section is inside Zimbabwe and no Botswana segment is dated.

The western corridor did produce a Botswana segment. Alongside the Kasane memorandum the two sides disclosed that [MTC has completed the Gobabis-Buitepos fibre link, now interconnecting with BoFiNet at Charles Hill](#) — described as the first direct cross-border fibre link between the two operators — and costed the Trans-Kalahari Corridor's remaining 4G gaps at about N\$52 million across 13 new sites. The two national incident-response teams are also said to be deepening cooperation. No capacity, commissioning date or traffic figure is published for the fibre link.

Domestic access moved on a much smaller scale. The backbone company [completed its 2025/26 local access projects at P43m, taking fibre to Moshupa, Ramotswa/Taung and Thamaga and connecting 191 customers — 68, 66 and 57 across the three — with 210 construction jobs](#). The customer count is the operator's own and is a count of connections, not of premises passed.

Data Storage

The Kala data centre [completed its first full quarter of continuous operation to 30 June, with revenue the company itself describes as modest and at proof-of-concept scale](#). It is designed for up to 1 MW and expansion is subject to funding. The base holds nothing on the facility before September 2025.

Energy

The facility's power is the unusual part. [On-site gas-fired generation is supplemented by solar introduced to cover periods of lower gas availability, with battery and compressed-gas storage under review](#) — solar specified as firming for gas, the reverse of the usual diesel-backup arrangement. [An initial 5 MW solar development was assessed during the quarter and an extension of the gas gathering network to connect a further production well is stated subject to funding](#); neither carries a capital cost, approval or date, and the company states both are work-programme items rather than guidance. The second gates the data centre: capacity growth turns on upstream gas work rather than on demand.

Cybersecurity

A published account documents a [growing digital safety problem](#). It is journalistic and carries no measure: no incident count, reporting route or response instrument accompanies it, which is what the record can and cannot say.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

Two identity-layer systems showed capacity problems rather than design problems this month. The public accounts committee was told on 30 July that the [national public key infrastructure has P423m secured, control transferred to the intelligence directorate, and no working system, timeline or accountable owner](#). On the committee's account Botswana has no certificate-backed identity verification and no recognised electronic-signature layer. The ministry's own headline figure appears as both P420m and P423m in the single account.

On 28 July a parliamentary answer put identity-card replacement delays down to [too few production staff and ageing equipment with frequent breakdowns](#). The delays have run since the start of 2026 and the answer carries no backlog figure, no restoration date and no equipment-replacement commitment.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The month's three payments developments are all commercial and narrow. A commercial bank and the Yellow Light Taxi Association [launched card acceptance on the bank's mobile tap product for taxi operators in Gaborone on 9 August](#), with access to business loans of up to P60,000 conditioned on the formal banking history the operators build through it. It is one bank and one association; no operator count, uptake figure or fee schedule is stated, and the credit on offer is tied to banking with the institution providing the terminal. Nine days later a remittance operator [issued a card on its wallet through a commercial bank and an international scheme](#), adding ATM withdrawal, in-store payment and domestic online purchase to a wallet that carried transfer and cash-out only. The operator's own account of the Companion Card puts the point of it plainly: [no separate bank account is required and the card works across every mobile network in the country, against an estimated 38 per cent of adults unbanked](#). Here too there is no customer count, issuance volume or fee schedule on the record. A commercial bank and an international card scheme then [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Botswana on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Botswana. The national payment switch and the citizen wallet both remain at Planned.

Registries

Against those two, one registry system entered testing this month. The electoral commission's [elections management system is built and under extensive testing, replacing platforms developed in the 1990s, for deployment at the 2029 general election](#); no supplier, cost or acceptance date is held, and the commission's secretary separately states as personal opinion that Batswana do not want electronic voting machines.

Sectoral management information systems

In the week of 13 July an [animal disease surveillance dashboard was launched, integrating the traceability system with district veterinary networks](#); the source is a paywalled lede and no coverage or user figure is held.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The government payroll portal was [taken offline on 22 July, with a privacy notice, an impact assessment, multi-factor authentication and disaster recovery added](#) and no reopening date stated. Separately, a tax adviser's reading of the new Value Added Tax Act, in force since 1 July, [puts mandatory electronic invoicing among the obligations the Act provides for](#), which would give the revenue service transaction-level visibility as sales occur. No start date, threshold or scope has been published, and the reading is the adviser's rather than the revenue service's.

Technology

ICT Industry

The incumbent operator reported [profit before tax of P146.2m for the year to 31 March, down 45%, on revenue of P1.47bn, down 1.6%](#). The figures are company-reported, and the [prior year is given as P259m in the 2025 account against P266.6m in the 2026 one](#) — unreconciled.

Innovation ecosystem

Two instruments for the innovation system arrived within three days of each other. The technology innovation agency of South Africa and the Botswana Digital and Innovation Hub [agreed a five-year joint programme and fund covering co-funding, commercialisation and cross-border work on 27 July](#). Two days later the communications minister [presented a Bill to create a national research and innovation council, reporting the national innovation system ranked 87th of 139 in the 2025 Global Innovation Index with research and development intensity below 0.5 per cent of output](#). The diagnosis in the second is the case for the first.

Capacity

Training and skills

A [P654.4m contract was awarded by direct procurement on 25 June for a STEAM e-learning, coding and robotics programme](#), its financial evaluation received, adjudicated and approved the same day and the decision published on 8 July. The Court of Appeal cleared the procurement route about six months earlier; that judgment is not held, and this rests on a paywalled lede.

Inclusion

Access to services

The Ministry of Youth and Gender Affairs [describes the Department of Gender Affairs as secretariat to the National Gender Commission](#), the standing institution behind this subject. Nothing else in the inclusion ledger moved in this window; the gender-based violence programme and the one-stop centres both date from earlier in the year.

Digital divides

Two school digital centres were handed over in the North West District on 22 and 23 July, at [P1.45m and P1.5m per site with thirty machines each](#). They are financed by the universal access and service fund, which draws a 1% levy on [mobile service providers](#); no programme total, annual allocation or school target has been published, and the per-site cost remains the only figure on the record. The base carried nothing on the fund's school programme before January 2026, so the two handovers are the whole of what is known about its delivery.

Data

National statistics

The statistics office and the national university [launched a second Statistics Development Strategy for 2026 to 2030 on 12 August](#), framed as a roadmap to an agile and responsive statistical system and aligned to the twelfth national development plan. No budget, delivery milestone or indicator set is published with it.

Geopolitics

China activities

China's ambassador [publicly offered AI cooperation in smart mining, digital government and talent training, pitching Chinese AI technology as a lever for economic diversification and pointing to a July 2026 pledge of 5,000 AI training places for developing countries and AI application cooperation centres for bodies including the African Union](#). It is an offer rather than an instrument: no Botswanan response, memorandum or programme is on file.

Gulf/UAE activities

The heads of agreement behind the data centre are unchanged, and the [operator's quarterly account of 3 August does not name the counterparty](#). It remains the only source of its kind the base holds for Botswana at any date.

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